# Associations and stories

## Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "brown = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

### From the body

Brown is the colour of **soil, bark, bread and coffee**. It is the colour of things you can pick up, taste or lean on. That is why we perceive it as **tangible**. At the same time it can recall mud or something spoiled, and the impression changes quickly accordingly.

### From culture

In Europe brown was long linked with **simplicity, labour and poverty**. The brown habit of monks, peasant linen, wooden furniture. Today it is also the colour of craft, coffee, chocolate and nature. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

### From what you have lived

Your grandparents' home, brown furniture, a jumper that kept you warm, or a wardrobe from which nothing could be thrown out. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same brown** and one smells cake and safety, the other hears the sentence "we don't do that here".

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "brown" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does brown connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**



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# Stories

Brown has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

## Mummy brown

Mummy brown was a pigment from ground bodies of Egyptian or Guanche mummies, mixed with white pitch and myrrh. It was valued for its transparency and its shade lies between burnt and raw umber. The first documented use dates from **1712**, when a Paris colour shop called "À la momie" sold mummy powder. In the mid-nineteenth century, in 1849, it was written that it was "in fashion".

The English painter Edward Burne-Jones is said to have buried his only tube in the garden in **1881** when he found out what it was made of. Production traditionally ended in the early twentieth century and by the middle of the century dealers had stopped offering it. Brown may seem ordinary, but its history was anything but.

## Sienna and umber

The name sienna comes from the Italian "terra di Siena", earth from Siena, the Tuscan city where the pigment was made in the Renaissance. In English the colour name is documented from **1760** and burnt sienna from **1853**. Sienna and umber are both natural earths with iron and manganese oxides, which is why umber is darker.

With umber, researchers dispute the origin of the name. According to some it is linked with the Italian region of Umbria, according to others with the Latin word umbra, that is, shadow. The main source of the pigment today is Cyprus. Pigments of this family are found already in the caves of Altamira and Lascaux. Brown really is a colour that comes from the earth.

## Sepia, brown ink from a cephalopod

Brown sepia paint was made from the ink sac of the cuttlefish. The word sepia is the Latinised form of the Greek word for cuttlefish. Sepia ink was used for writing as early as Greco-Roman times and artists drew with it until the nineteenth century.

In the last quarter of the eighteenth century a Dresden professor, Jakob Seydelmann, developed a process to make a concentrated form for watercolour and oil. Brown was thus not only a colour of the earth. More than once it also came from the sea.



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